him and promised reservations to the Marathas, with 'Kunbi certificates' affirming all claims. The critical part of his stand was that he would do this without trimming the quotas of existing beneficiaries. After his government failed to meet the demand within his 40-day deadline (October 25), Jarange-Patil launched another hunger strike. Things took a violent turn in Beed district; the houses and properties of OBC leaders were targeted.

The situation was volatile and everyone was walking on eggshells. At one point, Jarange-Patil lashed out at deputy CM and home minister Devendra Fadnavis, who sought immunity saying he was a soft target because he was a Brahmin. Not that those within the caste cohort fared any better. Shinde's other deputy CM, Ajit, meanwhile, had pitched for a caste census so that the quota net could be widened and everyone accommodated. He happened to allude to the opposition from existing OBCs to the Maratha demand and also spoke in favour of a foolproof quota move that would stand the test of law. Though his NCP is seen as Maratha-dominated, the protesters redirected their ire at him. Later, a timely attack of dengue allowed him to stay away from the public eye.

With his two deputies forced to retreat to the wings, Shinde had to lead the charge. A Fadnavis aide says the deputy CM worked to ensure that law and order was maintained, but the proactive political steps were all Shinde's. Sources close to him say there were concerns that the social tensions could even impact Diwali celebrations. He deputed his aide Mangesh Chivate, a former journalist who heads the CM's medical aid cell, to parley with Jarange-Patil. Chivate managed to get the activist to have his men go easy on the streets.

Meanwhile, the Shinde cabinet accepted the report of a committee led by Justice Sandeep Shinde (retd) that recommended the inclusion of Marathas from the Marathwada region in the backward classes category provided they have the genealogical records to prove their Kunbi lineage. A delegation of ministers flew to Antarwali-Sarati with two retired judges, M.G. Gaikwad and Sunil Shukre, to persuade the activist to withdraw his fast on November 2. "This may be the first time in history when the state roped in retired judges to convince an agitator to withdraw his protest," the source notes. To solidify the truce, the administration is working in mission mode to grant Kunbi caste certificates to Maratha applicants across the state. The Maratha-Kunbis are said to account for 31.5 per cent of Maharashtra's population, and the OBCs over 52 per cent. Realistic surmises put the Maratha numbers minus the Kunbis between 12 and 16 per cent.



ANY MARATHA CONSOLIDATION IN SHINDE'S FAVOUR MAY HELP HIM UNDERCUT ANY SYMPATHY FOR HIS EX-BOSS UDDHAV THACKERAY

The onus is now on Shinde to keep the OBCs suitably pacified. Already, NCP minister Chhagan Bhujbal has decried the liberal grant of OBC certificates to Marathas, sparking counter-fire from Maratha ministers and leaders. To that extent, the government may exude the sense of being a coalition of extremes. The jury is out on who will benefit from the polarisation, especially given the backdrop of the split in two principal parties—the Shiv Sena and the NCP. Sources in the NCP's Sharad Pawar faction rue that the eventual winner of this round may be the BJP. The path to the Lok Sabha polls will be eventful, with the state likely to see a new law to grant a ring-fenced quota to the Marathas in the budget session due early next year.

A legislator from Shinde's Shiv Sena says Jarange-Patil was seen as the leader of the common Marathas but Shinde's successful overtures to him have led to the CM being seen as the leader of this numerically significant group. "Shinde is seen as a non-elite Maratha, since he has no dynastic background in politics," he adds. An Ajit faction source affirms Shinde has taken the 'non-elite Maratha' crown. All this amid speculation on whether the BJP high command will replace Shinde with Ajit. Assembly speaker Rahul Narwekar has to decide on disqualification petitions against Shinde and his MLAs by December 31. This coincides with Jarange-Patil's fresh deadline to the state government. Besides helping protect his turf, a Maratha consolidation in Shinde's favour may help him undercut any sympathy his former boss-turned-bete noire Uddhav Thackeray in the community. The OBCs, core voters of the old Sena, are also upset with its Mumbai-centric, cosmopolitan leadership (read: Uddhav) for being unable to respond in what they see as their hour of crisis. A BJP senior admits Shinde has wrested the advantage on the Maratha front, but like Uddhav has to walk the tightrope to manage OBC polarisation for the NDA.

Hemant Desai, journalist and political commentator, gives the thumbs-up to the skills Shinde showed in tackling a crisis that could have "caught him in the vortex". That, too, when Fadnavis and Ajit bowed out. "Fadnavis went to an OBC protest and said the OBCs were in the BJP's DNA, which by extension means the Marathas are not part of this DNA," notes Desai. And Ajit never made any statement supporting Jarange-Patil or his demand. "Ajit will face turbulence if Maratha voters are disturbed," says Desai. Who benefits then? As of now, it's advantage Shinde. ■